ART DECO BEYOND BOMBAY

Atul Kumar, founder trustee, the Art Deco Mumbai Trust, recommends rare Art Deco masterpieces



PANJIM

"The Fontainhas district is worth a visit. Its Art Deco motifs are more modern than ethnic. Check out Anandi Nivas in Mapusa, Chowgule bungalow in Vasco Da Gama and Damodar Nivas in Panjim."



ART DECO PUNE

PUNE

"Though not as well documented, Art Deco in Pune is a visual feast. I particularly like the Bank of Maharashtra building and Khausara Gandhi and Bhatija. Named after the three owners, the latter has a classic asymmetrical form and intricate *jaali* work."



HYDERABAD/SECUNDERABAD

"The architecture of Arya Samaj Mandir is a cocktail of modern and vernacular. It looks like a stupa of a temple and yet, it's got a stepped profile (ziggurat), long continuous balconies and decorative motifs on its facade. It's a very unusual building that manages to combine both a religious expression and international spirit."

A Tale of Twin Cities

ARCHITECTURE

Separated by geography, Mumbai and Tel Aviv are united by architecture

Mumbai and Tel Aviv could well be soul cities, argues ***Architecture Moderne: Mumbai and Tel Aviv*** **(on view at the Claude Batley Gallery in Sir JJ College of Architecture, Mumbai until June 22)**. The exhibition, comprising 28 panels that juxtapose images of apartment and office buildings, hotels, cinema halls and religious spaces from the two cities, is an attempt to explore uncanny similarities in Mumbai and Tel Aviv's design patterns and aesthetics. Mumbai's 'Art Deco' is better known as the 'Bauhaus' style in Tel Aviv.

A Unesco World Cultural Heritage site since 2013, Tel Aviv's White City has 4,000 buildings whose modernist visual splendour rivals that of Mumbai's nearly 814 Art Deco buildings, mostly around Marine Drive and the adjacent Oval Maidan. Dr Micha Gross of the Bauhaus Center, Tel Aviv describes the White City as "cubistic sculptures" within the urban landscape. Dahlia Neumann, a Tel Aviv resident who has recently moved to Mumbai as the deputy consul general of the Consulate General of Israel, says, "Take a stroll around White City and then along Marine Drive. You can't tell the difference. There's a harmony in the style of architecture and a vibe that uplifts your mood."

Bauhaus in Tel Aviv and Art Deco in Bombay developed around the same time. In the 1930s and '40s, persecuted European Jews flocked to what was then Palestine in large numbers, resulting in a housing boom in Tel Aviv. Refugee architects brought Bauhaus with them. By comparison, Bombay was a leading economic hub. The high demand for modern housing was met by land reclamation schemes and plotted developments. Pioneering architects such as Master, Sathe and Bhuta; G.B. Mhatre; Gregson, Batley & King and Bhedwar and Bhedwar helped transform the city by marrying Art Deco with local sensibilities and needs. Art Deco, born as Style Moderne in the interwar years in Paris, quickly "caught the imagination of people across the nation, like wildfire", says the show's curator Mustansir Dalvi.

In Bombay, Art Deco started out as a symbol of modern living but soon acquired more egalitarian tones. "It's a completely wrong notion that it was meant only for the elite," says Dalvi. Visual aesthetics aside, buildings in Mumbai and Tel Aviv made use of common material. Dalvi claims that the rise of cement and related products was a breakthrough in the development of Art Deco. "Cement companies started aggressively marketing their products.... RCC (reinforced cement concrete) was valued for its flexibility and durability and allowed the Art Deco movement exciting creative possibilities that were previously unavailable." ■

–Shaikh Ayaz





STYLE COUSINS

Bauhaus in Tel Aviv (top), Art Deco in Mumbai

A flood of refugees sparked a housing boom in Tel Aviv. In Bombay, demand for modern housing was met by architects who fused Art Deco with local styles